

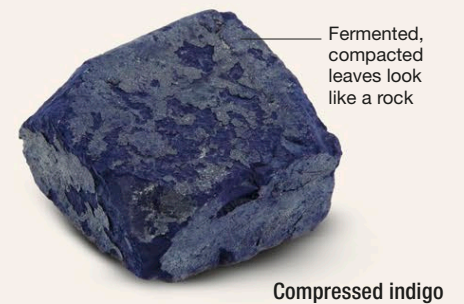


Orange and ochre The ochre on the woman's robe is an earth colour used in paintings – like this 1st-century CE fresco from Pompeii – but not in textiles. The cloth could have been dyed with cheap weld or goldenrod, or rare, expensive saffron from crocus stems.

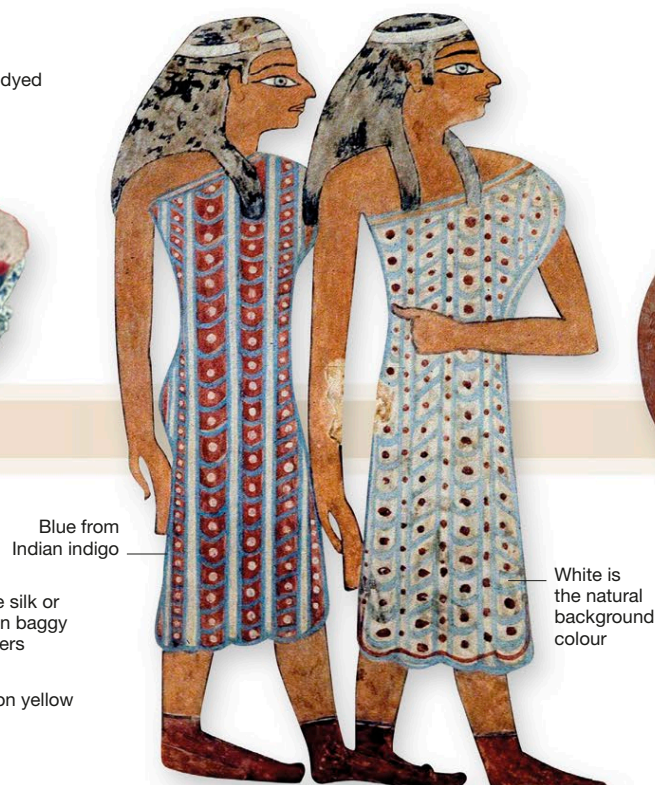
Green and contrasting colour This stylized figure is woven into a llama wool cloth for wrapping a mummy in the 3rd-century BCE Paracas culture of Peru. The lively textile patterns of pre-Columbian cultures use contrasting colours and shapes.

THE POPULARITY OF INDIGO

While some cosmetics were ruinous to health and beauty in the long term, indigo had special healing properties. Indigo is a natural antiseptic and was traditionally used in tattooing the skin. A major international trading commodity, indigo is one of the most readily available natural dyes around the world, although the quality and intensity can vary. It is sourced from different plants, depending on the climate. In Europe *Isatis tinctoria* (woad) was the source. Different species for indigo exist far and wide, from sub-Saharan Africa to Japan and India.



Chinese blue Blue from indigo was the most easily available dye, as the plants grew freely. This detail from a painted panel of Chinese silk shows a man both wearing blue and carrying a blue-and-white teapot.



Patterned clothing The patterns distinguish these Semite women of c.1900 BCE from Egyptians. Striped or patterned cloth may have been the biblical Joseph's "coat of many colours". The white cotton was block printed with wax to resist the dye, like batik.

Tyrian purple dyed cloth a rich red-violet and did not fade



Purple Tyrian, also called true, Imperial, or murex (from the sea snail that secreted it) purple was a precious dye farmed in the Mediterranean. It was reserved for imperial and high religious use or for rich diplomatic gifts. The Phoenician city of Tyre was a trade centre.